

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 15: Chromium and Flame

Day 45 Since Awakening - Iron Depths, Boss Chamber

The Chromium Colossus raised both fists and brought them down like sledgehammers. The entire chamber shook, metal floor buckling under the impact. Takeda barely rolled clear, his katana already glowing red-hot with fire enhancement.

"Formation Omega!" he shouted. "Damage dealers, go for joints! Healer, priority shields on frontline! Support team—"

The Colossus moved faster than something its size should be able to, one massive arm sweeping horizontally. It caught the hammer-wielder before she could dodge, sending her flying into the wall with bone-crushing force. She hit hard and didn't get up.

"Yamada!" The healer rushed toward the downed fighter, hands already glowing with healing magic.

The Colossus turned its attention to the healer.

"Oh no you don't." Himiko shifted mid-run, becoming a massive bear, and slammed into the Colossus's leg with her full weight. The boss staggered but didn't fall. It backhanded Himiko, and even in bear form, she was sent tumbling.

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS HP: 85,000/85,000]

The thing hadn't taken any damage yet. Its chromium body reflected attacks, absorbed impacts. B-rank defense to match its B-rank offense.

Hayami's mind raced through options. Metal monster. Conductive. But also highly resistant to physical damage. Lightning would work, but this wasn't like the Iron Golems—the Colossus was too large, too reinforced. They needed to weaken it first.

Fire. Heat metal until it became malleable, vulnerable.

But Hayami's fire manipulation was still E-rank, essentially useless. They'd need to rely on their mastered elements.

"Takeda!" Hayami called out. "Keep hitting it with fire magic! Superheat the metal!"

"Already on it!" Takeda's katana blazed as he struck at the Colossus's knee joint. The metal glowed dull red where his blade connected, but it wasn't enough.

Hayami activated Battle Meditation, feeling their mana regeneration double. Then they layered their domains.

"Lightning Domain! Earth Domain! Wind Domain!"

Three spheres of elemental energy exploded into existence, overlapping to create a tri-element field. The Colossus was caught in the center, immediately taking continuous damage from the lightning while earth constructs rose to restrict its movement and wind pressure pushed against it from all sides.

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS HP: 85,000 → 82,700]

The Colossus roared and swung both arms in a wide circle, breaking through the earth constructs. But the damage was being done—the lightning was heating its metal body from the inside, the domains restricting its movement enough for the team to regroup.

"It's working!" The second damage dealer—a spear user—struck at an already-heated joint. His spear penetrated where before it had bounced off.

Hayami launched Advanced Wind Blade in rapid succession, the compressed air slicing at joints and seams. Each blade opened gaps in the armor plating. Then Master Lightning Strike through Storm Fang, channeling B-rank electrical power directly into those gaps.

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS HP: 82,700 → 76,500]

The Colossus adapted. It slammed both fists into the ground, and suddenly metal spikes erupted from the floor—dozens of them, forcing the team to scatter. The domains destabilized, and Hayami had to dismiss them to avoid the spikes.

Himiko, back in human form, grabbed Hayami and pulled them behind a pillar. "This thing is insane! How do we kill something this big?"

"Same way we killed the Basilisk." Hayami's eyes tracked the Colossus's movements. "We wear it down, find the weak point, and hit it with everything we have."

"You have a plan?"

"Working on it."

The Colossus charged at Takeda, who barely managed to parry with his katana. The impact sent him skidding backward, his boots leaving grooves in the metal floor. The healer had stabilized Yamada, who was conscious but couldn't stand—her leg was broken.

They were down to five effective fighters against a B-rank boss. Not good odds.

Hayami pulled out Storm Fang and channeled power through it. The Mantle of the Storm billowed with wind and lightning. The Bracers of the Four Winds hummed with contained energy.

Time to stop holding back.

"Himiko, I need you to distract it for thirty seconds. Can you do that?"

"I can try." She shifted into a massive eagle and took flight, diving at the Colossus's head while shrieking. The boss swatted at her but she was too agile, darting around its attacks while clawing at its eyes—which were made of the same chromium as the rest of its body but slightly more vulnerable.

Hayami activated Elemental Domain Fusion again, but this time they poured more mana into it. The three domains expanded, intensified, became weapons rather than just areas of effect.

Then they used their new Elemental Forging technique. Earth rose from the floor—not to attack, but to create. Stone shaped itself into a massive spear, five meters long, dense as steel. Wind wrapped around it, reducing air resistance to nothing. Lightning channeled through it, turning it into a railgun projectile.

"Master Stone Lance: Railgun Configuration!"

The improvised technique combined earth, wind, and lightning at B-rank mastery. The massive spear launched with a crack of thunder, moving faster than sound, trailing lightning and wind as it crossed the chamber in a fraction of a second.

It struck the Colossus center-mass and punched clean through its chest, leaving a hole the size of a basketball.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [CHROMIUM COLOSSUS HP: 76,500 → 53,200]

Over twenty thousand damage in one hit. The Colossus staggered, chromium plating cracking around the wound.

"Now!" Takeda rallied the team. "Hit the wound! Everything you've got!"

The spear user drove his weapon into the hole. Takeda's katana followed, superheating the internal mechanisms. Himiko shifted into a serpent and slithered through the gap, tearing at whatever was inside.

Hayami didn't stop. They used Thunder Flash to appear behind the Colossus and drove Storm Fang into its back, channeling Master Lightning Strike at point-blank range. The electricity coursed through the boss's entire body.

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS HP: 53,200 → 38,900]

The Colossus thrashed wildly, metal limbs swinging in all directions. Takeda took a glancing blow and went down hard. The spear user barely dodged a follow-up attack.

But the boss was bleeding—not blood, but liquid metal that pooled on the floor. Its movements were becoming sluggish. The hole in its chest was expanding as the surrounding metal weakened from heat and electrical

damage.

Hayami made a decision. They planted their feet, activated Earthborn to root themselves immovably to the floor, and channeled every offensive skill they had.

"Plasma Burst! Cyclone! Earthquake!"

Three massive attacks, all B-rank power, launched simultaneously. The plasma wave engulfed the Colossus's upper body. The cyclone pulled it off balance. The earthquake destabilized its footing.

The boss fell, and when it hit the ground, the impact finished what the attacks had started. The chromium body fractured along stress lines, internal systems failing, the whole structure collapsing.

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS HP: 38,900 → 0]

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS DEFEATED]

[URGENT QUEST COMPLETE!]

[+20,000 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] x3

[LEVEL 30 → LEVEL 33]

[+15 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

The chamber fell silent except for heavy breathing and the sound of cooling metal. The Colossus's body was already dissolving into mist, leaving behind a pile of loot that glittered under the chamber's metallic lighting.

Takeda pushed himself upright, staring at Hayami with an expression somewhere between shock and respect. "That last attack... that was B-rank power. Multiple B-rank attacks at once."

Hayami was too tired to deflect. "Yeah."

"You're not E-rank." It wasn't a question.

"The license says E-rank. My actual capabilities are... more complicated."

The healer had reached Takeda and was checking him for injuries. The spear user just shook his head in disbelief. Yamada, still sitting against the wall with her broken leg, laughed weakly.

"We just killed a B-rank boss with a C-rank team. That's not supposed to be possible."

"It's possible," Himiko said, shifting back to human form, "when you have the right support." She looked at Hayami with obvious pride. "Told you they were capable."

Takeda stood, wincing but functional. "I owe you both an apology. Especially you, Amamiya. I underestimated you badly." He extended his hand. "Whatever your real capabilities are, you saved our lives today. Thank you."

Hayami shook his hand. "Just doing what needed to be done."

"More than that." Takeda pulled out his phone. "I'm adding you to my contact list. When I need reliable combat support—real combat support, not just babysitting—I'm calling you. Both of you."

They divided the loot. The Colossus had dropped rare chromium ingots worth a fortune, high-grade magic stones, and one exceptional item: a B-rank skill book for Metal Manipulation.

[SKILL BOOK: METAL MANIPULATION (BASIC) - RANK D] [Description: Control and shape metal with your will. Synergizes well with other elemental abilities.]

Hayami absorbed it immediately, feeling the knowledge settle into their mind. Metal was earth's refined cousin—structured, purified, enhanced. With their B-rank earth manipulation as foundation, learning metal control would be rapid.

[NEW ABILITY ACQUIRED: METAL MANIPULATION (BASIC) - Rank D]

The payment was distributed: ¥180,000 each as contracted, plus significant bonuses for the unexpected B-rank boss. Hayami's total take was ¥310,000.

As they prepared to leave, Takeda pulled Hayami aside one more time. "Listen, I know you've got your reasons for keeping the E-rank license. I won't pry. But if you ever need work, call me. I run a semi-independent operation—we take contracts from multiple guilds but stay unaffiliated. Good pay, experienced teams, and we don't ask questions about power levels as long as you're reliable."

He handed over a business card. "Think about it."

Hayami pocketed the card. Two professional contacts now—Sato with Eclipse Guild, and Takeda's independent operation. Options were good.

14:36 - Walking Home

Hayami and Himiko walked through Tokyo together, both still wearing their combat gear. Other pedestrians gave them a wide berth—Hunters fresh from Gates tended to have an aura of violence that normal people instinctively avoided.

"So," Himiko said after a few blocks of comfortable silence, "you hit Level 33 from that fight?"

"Yeah. The experience from B-rank bosses is significant."

"I only hit Level 19. The gap between A-rank and your... whatever you actually are... is crazy." She bumped her shoulder against Hayami's. "Speaking of which, how's your element progression going? Last I heard, you had three at B-rank."

"Still three at B-rank. But I unlocked a fourth element after mastering wind."

"Fourth?!" Himiko stopped walking. "What element?"

"Fire. It's at E-rank right now, basically useless. But I have the Advanced Manual and some Elemental Awakening Elixirs. I'm planning to dedicate the next few days to mastering it."

"Can I watch?" The question came out before Himiko could stop herself. "I mean, if that's okay. I'm curious about how the elemental mastery thing works. And maybe I can learn something about controlling my shapeshifting better by watching you work with elements."

Hayami considered it. They'd been training alone on the apartment roof for weeks. Having someone there felt like it would be distracting. But Himiko was trustworthy, genuinely interested, and they were partners.

"Okay. You can come to my place. But the training space is just my apartment roof, and it's not fancy."

"I don't care about fancy!" Himiko's enthusiasm returned immediately. "This is going to be so cool!"

15:12 - Hayami's Apartment Roof

Himiko stood in the center of the roof, looking at the setup with fascination. Training dummies (most damaged or destroyed from previous sessions), concrete blocks with scorch marks and cracks, remnants of earth constructs, and the general wear that came from practicing destructive magic in a confined space.

"This is where you do all your training?" She walked over to a particularly scorched section. "These burn marks... you really just practice up here?"

"Where else would I practice? The training gyms are too public." Hayami pulled out the Advanced Fire Manipulation Manual. "Fire is going to be trickier. More destructive, harder to contain. I might cause some visible damage."

"I can keep watch and make sure no one comes up." Himiko sat down on an intact section of roof. "Go ahead. Show me how an Arbiter masters an element."

Hayami opened the manual to the first exercise, but before starting, they pulled out one of the Elemental Awakening Elixirs and drank it.

[ELEMENTAL AWAKENING ACTIVE] [DURATION: 24 HOURS] [FIRE MANIPULATION PROFICIENCY GAIN: +200%]

Fire awakened within them more aggressively than the other elements. It didn't want to be controlled—it wanted to consume, spread, grow. But Hayami had mastered three elements already. They knew how to impose their will on elemental forces.

"Exercise 1: Flame Creation. Fire is transformation made manifest—matter becoming energy, potential becoming kinetic. Create flame from nothing. Will it into existence."

Hayami held out their palm and focused. Not on heat or energy, but on the concept of transformation. Changing the state of matter, releasing stored energy, initiating the chemical reaction.

A small flame appeared above their hand, barely larger than a candle's.

"Whoa," Himiko breathed. "That's fire from nothing. No fuel, no spark, just... will."

[FIRE MANIPULATION: E-Rank (0% → 8%)]

The elixir was working. Eight percent from one exercise. At this rate, they could reach C-rank by evening.

Hayami continued through the exercises, Himiko watching in fascinated silence. Creating larger flames. Shaping fire into specific forms. Launching fireballs that exploded against the concrete blocks. Learning to feel the heat as something they controlled rather than something that controlled them.

[FIRE MANIPULATION: E-Rank (8% → 34% → 67% → 89%)]

Hours passed. The sun began to set, painting the Tokyo skyline in reds and oranges that matched the flames dancing across Hayami's hands.

"Exercise 12: Fire's Nature. Fire is not merely destruction. It is renewal, purification, the force that clears old growth so new life can flourish. Understand this duality to progress."

Hayami created a sphere of flame and watched it burn. The fire wanted to spread, to consume. But it also transformed—matter became heat, heat became light, energy was released and redistributed. Nothing was truly destroyed, only changed.

[FIRE MANIPULATION: E-Rank (89% → 100%)]

[CONGRATULATIONS!] [FIRE MANIPULATION: E-RANK → D-RANK (0%)]

The breakthrough was expected. Hayami pushed harder, working through the intermediate exercises as the elixir's effect made every insight come faster, every technique easier to grasp.

By the time full darkness had fallen and city lights glittered below, fire had reached C-rank.

[FIRE MANIPULATION: D-RANK → C-RANK (0%)]

Himiko had been silent for the last hour, just watching. Now she stood and approached Hayami carefully.

"That was incredible. You went from not being able to create fire to... that." She gestured at the flames still dancing around Hayami's hands. "How long did it take you to master lightning the first time?"

"About three weeks of daily practice. But I had no idea what I was doing then." Hayami dismissed the flames.

"Now I understand the pattern. Each element has its own nature, but the process of mastery is similar."

"And you're going to master fire completely? Like B-rank?"

"That's the plan. Probably tomorrow or the next day, depending on how the training goes." Hayami checked the time—9:47 PM. "You should head home. It's getting late."

"Yeah, I should." Himiko hesitated. "Thanks for letting me watch. And for... everything today. The raid, having my back with Takeda, saving the team from that boss."

"We're partners. That's what partners do."

Himiko smiled and pulled Hayami into a quick hug. "Best partners. Text me tomorrow!"

She left, and Hayami stood alone on the roof, watching the city lights. Their phone showed several notifications—missed calls from unknown numbers, probably other Hunters who'd heard about the Chromium Colossus kill and wanted to recruit them.

But before dealing with that, they had a reward to claim.

[LEGENDARY REWARD BOX - CHROMIUM COLOSSUS]

Hayami opened the box, and golden light spilled out.

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[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: PRIMORDIAL DAGGER SET - "TWIN FANG"] [Description: A pair of legendary daggers forged from primordial essence, designed specifically for the Arbiter] [Main Hand - **STORM FANG EVOLUTION**] [Off Hand - **TERRA FANG**] [Combined Stats: +20 to all stats] [Passive: All elemental attacks deal 50% additional damage when both daggers are wielded] [Passive: Each dagger enhances its corresponding elements—Storm Fang (Lightning/Wind), Terra Fang (Earth/Fire)] [Active Skill: **ELEMENTAL TWIN STRIKE** - Attack with both daggers simultaneously, each one carrying different elements. Creates devastating combination attacks. Costs 300 Mana. Cooldown: 1 minute.]

[Growth Weapons: These weapons evolve as you master more elements]

Storm Fang transformed in Hayami's hand, becoming sleeker, sharper, etched with patterns of lightning and wind. The new dagger—Terra Fang—materialized in their other hand, earth-brown with veins of crimson fire.

[SKILL BOOK ACQUIRED: ADVANCED METAL MANIPULATION] [Jump to C-rank Metal Manipulation immediately]

Hayami absorbed it, feeling their understanding of metal expand dramatically.

[METAL MANIPULATION: D-RANK → C-RANK (0%)]

[CONSUMABLE ACQUIRED: PRIMORDIAL ESSENCE (PURE)] [Description: A crystallized drop of pure primordial energy] [Effect: Permanently increases all stats by +10. Can trigger Arbiter class evolution if conditions are met. Single use.]

Hayami stared at the shimmering crystal. Ten permanent stat points. They used it immediately.

[ALL STATS +10]

The power surge was intense. Their body adapted, strengthened, optimized. This was beyond normal stat increases—this was fundamental enhancement.

They checked their updated status:

[LEVEL: 33] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 3)]

[STATS] (with all equipment including new daggers)

- Strength: 198 (with Twin Fang bonuses)
- Agility: 264 (approaching S-rank threshold)
- Vitality: 182
- Intelligence: 281 (solidly S-rank)
- Sense: 200 (hitting A/S-rank boundary)
- Mana: 3,310/3,310

[ELEMENTS]

- Lightning Manipulation (B-Rank 0%)
- Earth Manipulation (B-Rank 0%)
- Wind Manipulation (B-Rank 0%)
- Fire Manipulation (C-Rank 0%)
- Metal Manipulation (C-Rank 0%)

Five elements. Three at B-rank. Two at C-rank. Intelligence breaking 280. Agility approaching the 270 S-rank threshold.

Hayami was no longer pretending to be E-rank. They were solidly A-rank in capability, approaching S-rank in specialized areas.

The question was: how much longer could they maintain the E-rank cover?

As if sensing the thought, the System pinged with a mentor notification:

[MENTOR CONSULTATION AVAILABLE]

Hayami focused on the notification, and suddenly they could sense the Primordial Force's attention focusing on them from... wherever concept-beings existed.

"Mentor. I have a question."

"Ask, young Arbiter." The voice echoed in their mind, not their ears.

"Should I do a rank reassessment with the Association? Being E-rank with this power is drawing attention. Other Hunters are noticing. It's becoming a liability."

There was a pause, as if the Primordial Force was considering multiple timelines simultaneously.

"The question is not should, but when. Revelation carries consequences—scrutiny, expectations, attempts to control or weaponize your growth. The Association would want to study how an E-rank achieved such power. They would monitor, restrict, interfere."

"So you're saying stay E-rank?"

"I am saying: time your revelation wisely. When you have mastered all seven elements, when the Arbiter path is complete, no force in this world can constrain you. Reveal yourself then, from a position of absolute strength. Until that moment..." The presence seemed to smile, though it had no face. *"Let them underestimate you. Weakness perceived is strength disguised."*

"How long until I can master all seven elements?"

"At your current rate? With the tools you possess? Three months. Perhaps four. Lightning, earth, and wind reached B-rank in six weeks. Fire will follow within days. Water, ice, and nature will come faster as your understanding deepens. You are accelerating, not slowing."

Three to four months. That was... surprisingly achievable. Hayami had expected years.

"So I just focus on mastering elements. Ignore the attention, keep grinding, reach completion before revealing anything."

"Precisely. And remember: the Association measures power in ranks. But the Arbiter transcends such limitations. You are not A-rank or S-rank. You are becoming something that no rank adequately describes. Let

them use their inadequate measurements. You know your true worth."

The presence faded, leaving Hayami alone with their thoughts.

Three to four months to master all seven elements. Then reveal the truth. Until then, maintain the E-rank cover, ignore the attention, focus entirely on progression.

The path was clear.

Hayami looked at the Twin Fangs in their hands—Storm Fang and Terra Fang, legendary weapons that would grow with them. At the Crown of the Arbiter with its four glowing gems. At the city stretching out below, unaware that something unique was being forged in its midst.

Forty-five days since Awakening. Level 33. Five elements unlocked, three at B-rank. Two legendary weapons. Multiple S-rank stats. A cosmic entity as a mentor. A best friend who trusted them. Professional contacts with established Hunters.

And a timeline: three to four months until completion.

Hayami smiled—a small, determined expression—and went inside. Tomorrow would bring another daily quest, more fire training, and continued progression.

The grind continued. But now with clear purpose, clear timeline, clear endgame.

Master seven elements. Transcend the ranking system. Become what the Arbiter was meant to be.

Three to four months.

They could do that.

[END OF CHAPTER 15]

[UPDATED STATUS SUMMARY]

[LEVEL: 33] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 3)] [DAYS SINCE AWAKENING: 45] [MENTOR: PRIMORDIAL FORCE (NAMELESS)]

[ELEMENTS]

- Lightning Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Earth Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Wind Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Fire Manipulation (C-Rank 0%) - UNLOCKED

- Metal Manipulation (C-Rank 0%) - UNLOCKED

[STATS] (with all equipment)

- Strength: 198
- Agility: 264 (approaching S-rank)
- Vitality: 182
- Intelligence: 281 (S-rank)
- Sense: 200
- Mana: 3,310

[NEW EQUIPMENT]

- Twin Fang Daggers (Storm Fang + Terra Fang)
- +20 all stats, 50% elemental damage, growth weapons

[FINANCES]

- Current Balance: ¥1,497,000

[RELATIONSHIPS]

- Himiko Nakayama: Best Friend/Partner
- Sato Kenji: Professional Contact (Eclipse Guild)
- Takeda: Professional Contact (Independent Operations)
- Primordial Force: Mentor

[TIMELINE TO COMPLETION]

- Estimated: 3-4 months to master all 7 elements
- Current: 3 elements mastered, 4 elements unlocked
- Strategy: Maintain E-rank cover until full mastery achieved

[NEXT OBJECTIVES]

- Master Fire element (priority)
- Continue daily quest streak (22 consecutive days)
- Train Metal manipulation to B-rank

- Unlock remaining 2 elements (Water, Ice, Nature)
- Achieve complete Arbiter transformation